



Strong Goals + Your Reach Job

AVC 248 • Design Self-Promotion • Week 4

“A vague goal can’t guide a single decision.”

THE PROBLEM

Most goals are too vague

Ask a designer their career goal and you usually get one foggy sentence. It sounds nice, but it can't actually steer anything.



Too broad

"I want a design job" fits a thousand roles and points at none of them.



No detail

No industry, no setting, no day-to-day. Nothing to plan around.



No direction

If it can't pick your next task, it can't guide your semester.

A goal you can't act on isn't really a goal yet.

What a strong goal includes

A strong goal is specific enough to plan around. It names all of these pieces:



Role



Industry



Setting



Location



Day-to-day



Timeline



Values



Pay range

Name all eight, and your goal can finally do its job.

SEE THE DIFFERENCE

Weak vs. strong goal



Weak

"I want to get a graphic design job somewhere good after I graduate."

No role, industry, setting, pay, or timeline. Nothing to build on.



Strong

"Junior motion designer at a mid-size brand studio in Denver or remote, animating social and product spots day-to-day, hired within a year, on a team that values craft, paying \$58K to \$68K."

Every piece is named. You can plan around it.

Same person. One version you can act on.

MAKE IT REAL

Pick one reach job posting

Now turn the goal into something concrete: find one real job posting that excites you, just out of reach, and make it your anchor.



Real posting

An actual listing you found, not a made-up wish.



A reach

Slightly above your current level, something to grow into.



Your anchor

It holds the whole semester's work steady in one place.

One posting, chosen on purpose, beats a hundred maybes.

ONE TARGET

Everything aligns to it

Once your reach job is set, every assignment this semester points back at it. That is what keeps your work focused.



Your reach job

sits at the center of it all.



Resume tailored to its exact requirements.



Interview prep built around its team and role.



Skill-building aimed at the gaps it reveals.

One job, total alignment. No wasted effort, no guessing what to work on next.

WHY REACH

Aim a little higher

A reach job stretches you on purpose. Even if you don't land that exact role, the work you do chasing it lifts everything.



It pulls you up

Building toward a stretch role grows skills a safe job never would.



It keeps you motivated

A job you actually want is worth the steady effort all term.



You're ready either way

Land it, or land the next tier down fully prepared. You win both.

Reach high. The climb is where the growth happens.



**Your goal and reach job
are the foundation.**

“Everything else is built on top of this.”